

Phrasal Verbs Without Objects

These phrasal verbs can be used without a direct object. Learn what each one means, read the examples, and then complete the short quiz.

Language note Some of these verbs have other meanings when they are used with an object. This handout focuses only on uses that do not need one.

Meanings and Examples

01 Calm down

Meaning to become less upset, nervous, or excited

- Take a slow breath and calm down.
- The children calmed down after a few minutes.
- She was angry at first, but she soon calmed down.

02 Turn up

Meaning to arrive or appear, often unexpectedly or later than expected

- Ben turned up half an hour late.
- Only six people turned up for the meeting.
- My missing keys finally turned up under the sofa.

03 Stay up

Meaning to remain awake instead of going to bed

- We stayed up until midnight.
- I cannot stay up late on a work night.
- The children stayed up to watch the fireworks.

04 Lie down

Meaning to put your body in a flat or resting position

- You look tired, so lie down for a while.
- He lay down on the grass and closed his eyes.
- I am going to lie down until my headache passes.

05 Break down

Meaning to stop working, or to lose control of your emotions

- Our car broke down on the way home.
- The elevator has broken down again.
- She broke down when she heard the sad news.

06 Take off

Meaning to leave the ground and begin flying; it can also mean to become successful very quickly

- The plane took off at nine o'clock.
- A flock of birds took off from the field.
- Her new business really took off last year.

07 Grow up

Meaning to develop from a child into an adult

- I grew up in a small town.
- What do you want to be when you grow up?
- The cousins grew up together.

08 Dress up

Meaning to wear formal, special, or unusually smart clothes

- You do not need to dress up for the party.
- We dressed up for the wedding.
- Everyone dressed up and went out for dinner.

09 Pass away

Meaning a polite way to say that someone has died

- Her grandfather passed away last winter.
- The famous actor passed away at the age of ninety.
- He passed away peacefully at home.

10 Hold on

Meaning to wait for a short time

- Hold on while I find a pen.
- Can you hold on for a moment?
- She asked us to hold on until she returned.

11 Run away

Meaning to leave a place suddenly, usually to escape from danger or a difficult situation

- The thief ran away when the alarm sounded.
- Do not run away from the dog.
- The frightened horse ran away across the field.

Quick Quiz

Complete each sentence with the correct form of a phrasal verb from the word bank. Use each answer once.

break down

dress up

hold on

stay up

turn up

1. The bus _____, so we had to walk home.
2. Please _____ for a minute while I check your reservation.
3. We usually _____ for formal dinners at that restaurant.
4. I cannot _____ late tonight because I have an early meeting.
5. Mia said she would come at eight, but she did not _____ until nine.

Extra practice

Write one sentence with a different phrasal verb from this handout.
